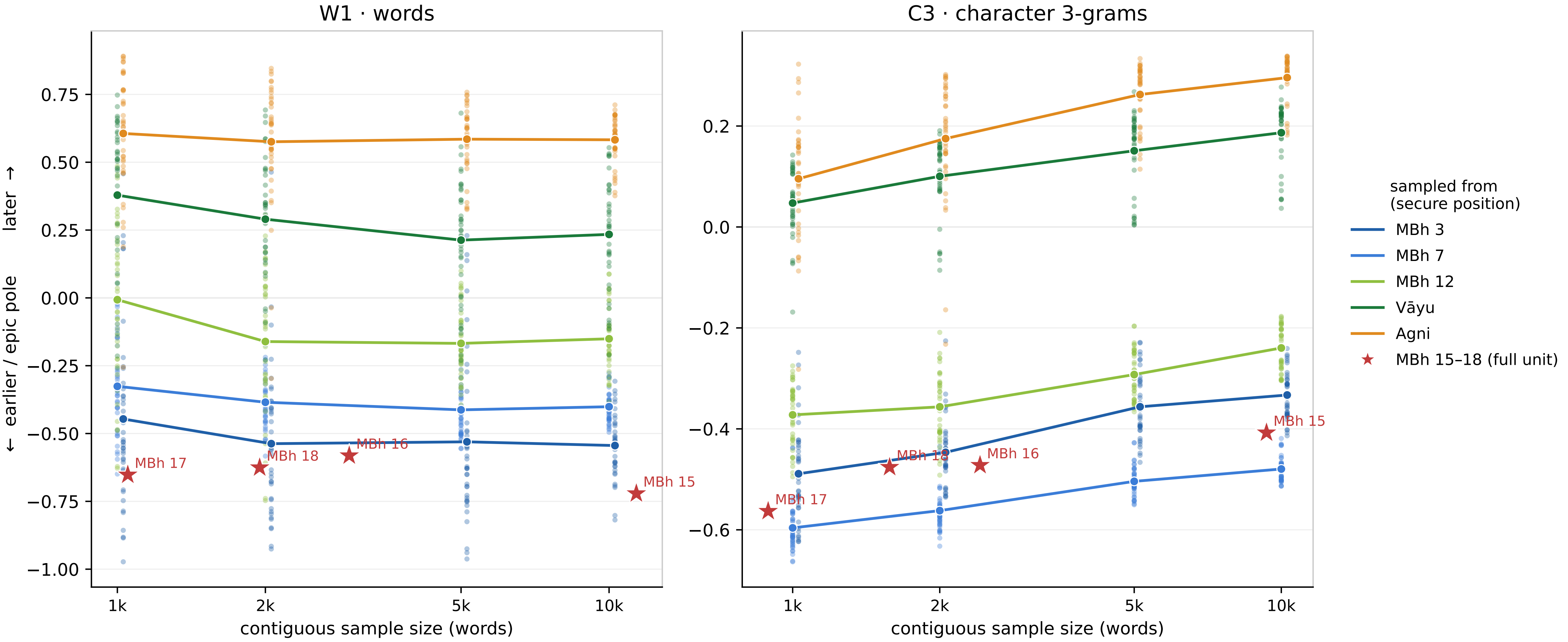
At the length of MBh 16–18, a late text can land at the epic pole

Random contiguous windows of securely-placed texts (MBh 3/7/12, Vāyu, Agni), each pushed through the identical pipeline and placed on the opening map. Two failure modes converge on the same length: the 3-gram lens drifts systematically leftward as the window shrinks, while the word lens keeps its mean but scatters so widely that single short windows reach the epic pole. The closing parvans (red) are single draws that small — MBh 16–18 sit inside the 1–2k scatter; only MBh 15, four times longer, stands apart.



Yet length is not the whole story: merged into one ~17k-word unit the closing parvans stay at the pole, not out by MBh 11/14.
So their position is register — low expository-particle overlay, narrative-pure text — not length, and not noise.